heavy chisels along the required area of the cave. This was followed by rough chiselling to bring out the cave's overall outline. From the chisel marks it appears that the work progressed from bottom to top. The chisel edges were very sharp, ranging between 0.7 and 1.3 cm—the marks preserved inside the cave and outside it suggest this. After this, the dressing of the interior was done, now with a lighter chisel. Dressing involved making parallel straight grooves over a comparatively even surface. These can be seen on the floor and on the outer face of the hut inside the cave. The depth to which the grooves were cut seems to have been a consequence of keeping in mind the surface which was to be eventually polished.

The dressed stone was then treated by pecking and grinding. Pecking involves thinning the ridges left behind by chiselling so that some kind of flat surface is produced. The hewn surface, though, still remained rough. This was evened out by grinding—the surface was rubbed by using coarse sand, water, and a coarse-grained stone. This removed all marks: the pitted parts, the coarse texture, etc. The smoothened surface then had to be polished. Polishing was only a kind of grinding where the rubbing stone used was of a fine texture, just as the sand too was very fine grained. In these caves, the polishing actually produced a glistening surface because the rock had large mineral particles like feldspar and hornblende which have shining properties. These are the particles which reflect like brilliant mirrors to this day.

This summary of the several stages involved in creating caves in a granite hill points to a meticulous process and careful planning. Creating a set of edifices on this scale needed lavish outlays. The overall impression of such a construction programme is the trouble to which the emperor is prepared to put himself to for religious sects and cults. Mendicants and ascetics of some authority considered worthy of such abodes by the powerful Magadhan court will, in turn, have altered social perceptions of the worth and power of asceticism and mendicancy. The hollowing out of a